
Beyond the Numbers

Decolonizing Learning Outcomes and Reclaiming Educational Purpose for Peace in African Schooling

Nene Onyedi Ibezim · Comparative and International Education Society (CIES) Annual Conference 2026

Keywords: decoloniality · Ubuntu · Omoluabi · learning outcomes · peace-affirming assessment · epistemic harm · Africa · educational justice

◆ A B S T R A C T

Across Africa, the quality of education is increasingly measured through test scores, completion rates, and standardized indicators imported from global policy frameworks. While such metrics offer a form of accountability, their dominance narrows the purpose of schooling, reducing learners to units of performance and displacing what many African communities have long regarded as the deeper aims of education: dignity, belonging, cultural continuity, and the capacity to live well together.

This paper argues that outcome-based governance, though presented as neutral and universal, carries market-oriented assumptions rooted in colonial epistemologies that inflict epistemic harm by marginalizing the relational, moral, and communal foundations of African educational life. Drawing on decolonial theory and the African philosophy of Ubuntu (I am because we are), this paper develops a theoretical critique of global learning-outcomes agendas and their collision with local ecologies of learning in Africa. It then examines how Ubuntu-centered traditions of schooling are rendered invisible by frameworks that only recognize what can be tested and ranked.

In response, the paper proposes peace-affirming assessment as a constructive alternative. Repositioning schools not as production sites but as spaces of identity, healing, and shared purpose. The paper concludes that decolonizing what counts and who decides it is not a retreat from rigor but an act of educational justice.

Quality cannot be imported through international templates; it must be negotiated in community, expressed in local languages, and measured by tools humble enough to recognize what matters most.

I. Introduction

Every school morning in Ikangba, a community in Ogun State, southwestern Nigeria, a quiet procession takes shape. Children, some in worn uniforms, some barefoot, most carrying well-used bags, set out from their homes and begin the walk to the one public primary school that serves the community, situated on its outskirts. The path takes them past the homes of elders: men and women who sit outside in the early morning air, watching the day begin.

As each child passes, they stop. They bow. They offer a greeting in Yoruba, "Ẹ káàárọ" (good morning) and they wait to receive a response before moving on. No teacher organizes this. No curriculum mandates it. No examination will ever assess it and yet something profoundly educational is happening on that path every single day.

The children are learning that age commands respect, that community membership carries obligations, that one does not pass another person, especially an elder, without acknowledgment. They are being formed, in the most literal sense, by the community through which they walk. They are becoming, in the language of the Yoruba moral tradition, "Omoluabi" (persons of good character) whose humanity is expressed through attentiveness to others.

Inside the school, a different authority speaks. It does not record the morning walk, does not credit it, does not consider it education at all. Here, learning begins when the bell rings.

The tragedy of the present moment is that the systems designed to improve African schooling have no framework for recognizing this — and no accountability mechanism that would require them to.

What unfolds each morning in Ikangba is not unique to one community. It points to a tension playing out, in different forms and with different cultural textures, across the African continent. From Lagos to Lusaka, from Nairobi to Niamey, educational reform has been increasingly driven by a powerful and pervasive global script; raise learning outcomes, improve test scores, increase completion rates, and demonstrate progress through standardized, internationally comparable indicators.

These imperatives arrive bearing the authority of multilateral development organizations, bilateral donors, and global assessment architectures, among them the World Bank's learning crisis agenda, the Sustainable Development Goal 4 framework, and regional instruments such as the Southern and Eastern Africa Consortium for Monitoring Educational Quality (SACMEQ) and the Programme d'Analyse des Systèmes Éducatifs de la CONFEMEN (PASEC). They speak the language of accountability, efficiency, and evidence. They also carry, often beneath the surface, a particular and consequential vision of what education is fundamentally for, one rooted in human capital theory, market-oriented governance, and a conception of the learner as an individual unit of productive and measurable potential (Biesta, 2009; Maluleka, 2024).

This paper argues that this vision is neither neutral nor universal. It is, in significant respects, a colonial inheritance, a continuation, through the machinery of global policy, of the longstanding project of remaking African persons, communities, and knowledge systems in alignment with Western epistemological assumptions. As Ngũgĩ wa Thiong'o (1986) argued in *Decolonising the Mind*, colonialism's most enduring weapon was not the gun but the systematic destruction of the colonized people's belief in their own names, languages, and ways of seeing the world.

Outcome-based governance continues this project by different means. When it becomes the dominant logic of African schooling, it does not merely measure educational quality, it redefines it, narrowing what counts as learning, who counts as a successful learner, and what purposes schools are socially and morally permitted to serve. The result is a form of epistemic harm, the systematic marginalisation of the relational, moral, and communal aims that have historically anchored education in African life (Mignolo, 2009; Assié-Lumumba et al., 2022).

This epistemic harm is not a concern confined to educational philosophy. It is a peace concern. Fanon (1963) demonstrated that colonialism's most lasting damage is not material but psychological and relational. It fractures the colonized person's relationship to their own identity,

their community, and their capacity for solidarity with others. Galtung (1969) distinguished between negative peace, the absence of direct violence and positive peace, the presence of justice, social cohesion, and the structural conditions for human flourishing. Schools organized around Ubuntu (I am because we are) form people capable of solidarity, restoration, and communal wisdom: the building blocks of positive peace.

To develop this argument, the paper draws centrally on Ubuntu, the foundational African philosophical principle most often expressed as I am because we are. Ubuntu is not a slogan or a cultural footnote. It is a comprehensive moral and ontological orientation that has shaped educational practice across diverse African contexts for generations, finding rich expression in Yoruba thought through the concept of “*Omoluabi*” a person of integrated good character whose virtue is enacted in and through their relationships with others (Assié-Lumumba et al., 2022). The morning walk in Ikangba is a living Ubuntu curriculum, a daily practice of relational formation that produces not merely knowledgeable individuals, but persons constituted by their care for community.

This paper is situated within a growing body of decolonial scholarship that has exposed the colonality of knowledge embedded in global education policy (Mignolo, 2009; Quijano, 2000; Ndlovu-Gatsheni, 2013a, 2013b). The paper addresses this silence in three movements: the first, traces the rise of learning outcomes as a global policy script; the second examines the collision between this script and the living traditions of Ubuntu-centered learning in Africa; and the third proposes peace-affirming assessment as an alternative accountability framework.

II. Theoretical Framework

This paper draws on three interconnected theoretical traditions: decoloniality, Ubuntu philosophy, and peace education. These function as mutually reinforcing lenses that, together, expose what is at stake when schools are reduced to performance machines and illuminate what becomes possible when they are freed to pursue fuller human purposes.

2.1 Decoloniality as the Primary Analytical Lens

Any serious engagement with African education must reckon with coloniality and not colonialism as a historical period that ended with formal independence, but coloniality as an ongoing structure of power that continues to shape what counts as knowledge, whose knowledge counts, and who has the authority to define educational purpose. Quijano (2000) argued that one of the foundational axes of the modern colonial world order was the racial classification of populations. A classification that did not disappear with decolonization but became embedded in the institutions, epistemologies, and social structures of postcolonial societies. In Africa, independence changed the flag; it did not dismantle the epistemological architecture that colonial schooling constructed.

Mignolo (2009) developed the concept of epistemic disobedience, the active refusal to accept the terms set by Western epistemology as the universal standard against which all other ways of knowing are measured. Mignolo's prescription, epistemic disobedience, is not a rejection of all external knowledge, but an insistence on the right to think, know, and educate from one's own location. Ndlovu-Gatsheni (2013a, 2013b) articulated the concept of epistemic freedom, the right and capacity of African peoples to think, theorize, and interpret the world from where they are located, without being required to first pass through the epistemological gatekeeping of Western academic traditions.

Biesta (2009) described the "learnification" of education: the transformation of educational discourse into a vocabulary of learning outcomes and measurable competencies that displaces substantive questions about educational purpose. Biesta identified three irreducible domains of educational purpose; qualification, socialization, and subjectification, and argued that measurement culture collapses all three into the first, while remaining structurally blind to the relational and identity-forming dimensions that the other two domains address.

2.2 Ubuntu as Philosophical Counterpoint and Constructive Resource

If decoloniality names what is wrong with the current arrangement, Ubuntu names what an alternative might look like and why it matters. Ubuntu (I am because we are) is a comprehensive moral and ontological orientation that holds that personhood is not a pre-social given but a relational achievement. One becomes a person through community, through the relationships, obligations, practices, and forms of mutual recognition that constitute communal life. For education, the implications are profound: if persons are constituted through relationship, then education cannot be primarily about developing isolated individual competencies.

Ubuntu's conception of educational purpose stands in direct tension with the human capital framework that drives global learning outcomes agendas. Where human capital theory treats education as an investment in individual productive capacity, Ubuntu treats it as a practice of communal formation. Where outcomes frameworks ask what the learner can demonstrate, Ubuntu asks what kind of person the learner is becoming and what kind of community they can sustain (Assié-Lumumba et al., 2022).

In the Yoruba-speaking communities of southwestern Nigeria, including Ikangba in Ogun State, Ubuntu finds its localized expression in the concept of Omoluabi: a person of integrated moral character whose virtue is enacted in and through their relationships with others. The Omoluabi ideal encompasses respect for elders, truthfulness, communal responsibility, emotional intelligence, and the capacity for restorative engagement with conflict. This paper treats that practice not as an ethnographic detail but as a theoretical resource: evidence that African communities possess rich, coherent, and sophisticated frameworks for educational purpose that long predate and substantially exceed the ambitions of any standardized assessment regime.

2.3 Peace Education as Normative Horizon

The most foundational contribution comes from Galtung's (1969) landmark distinction between negative peace, the absence of direct violence and positive peace, the presence of social justice, equity, and the structural conditions for human flourishing. An education system may produce graduates who do not engage in physical conflict while simultaneously reproducing the conditions of inequality, alienation, and cultural erasure that make structural violence possible. Outcome-based schooling can deliver negative peace, trained, compliant individuals while actively undermining the conditions for positive peace by eroding the relational and communal fabric through which communities sustain themselves.

Galtung (1990) extended his framework with the concept of cultural violence, aspects of culture, including education, that can be used to legitimize direct or structural violence, making inequality and exclusion appear natural or deserved. From this perspective, an educational system that consistently devalues African knowledge and marginalizes communal purposes is not merely pedagogically inadequate. It is, in Galtung's terms, culturally violent. This paper argues that without a decolonial regrounding, without Ubuntu as the philosophical foundation, peace education risks reproducing, in the domain of values education, the same epistemological displacement it critiques elsewhere.

Together, these three theoretical traditions form the analytical and normative architecture of the paper. Decoloniality exposes the colonial epistemological roots of outcome-based governance and demands epistemic freedom for African educational communities. Ubuntu provides the philosophical substance of that freedom. Peace education provides the normative stakes, connecting the decolonization of assessment to the broader project of building societies capable of justice, solidarity, and sustainable peace.

III. The Rise of the Outcomes Script: Tracing a Colonial Policy Architecture

The global learning outcomes agenda did not emerge spontaneously from the educational needs of African communities. It was constructed deliberately, institutionally, and over several decades by a network of international organizations, development banks, donor governments, and assessment industries whose influence over African education policy has grown in inverse proportion to the epistemic authority granted to African communities themselves.

3.1 Constructing the Learning Crisis: A Narrative of African Deficiency

The most authoritative articulation arrived with the World Bank's World Development Report 2018: Learning to Realize Education's Promise, the first World Development Report ever devoted entirely to education. The report declared a global learning crisis: despite dramatic gains in school enrollment across the developing world, millions of children were leaving school without acquiring basic reading, writing, or numeracy skills. The finding was not wrong. But the framing was deeply consequential. By defining educational quality almost entirely in terms of measurable cognitive outcomes, the report installed a particular epistemological architecture at the center of global education governance (World Bank, 2018).

The learning crisis narrative performs several important ideological functions. First, it positions Africa as educationally deficient relative to a standard defined by the Global North. Second, it constructs a particular solution: better measurement, stronger accountability, and more systematic assessment of learning outcomes, foreclosing any serious inquiry into whether the definition of learning being measured is itself appropriate, locally meaningful, or epistemologically defensible. Third, and most critically, the narrative renders invisible forms of educational achievement that do not register on cognitive assessments: relational formation, moral development, communal identity, and the capacities that sustain peace (Biesta, 2009).

Auld et al. (2019), writing in *Comparative Education*, demonstrated that the perception of a learning crisis was not discovered so much as amplified through selective use of assessment data, through the framing power of flagship reports, and through the political economy of development finance.

3.2 Assessment Architectures as Instruments of Governance

SACMEQ operationalizes educational quality almost exclusively through standardized assessments of reading and mathematics at the Grade 6 level. Its data architecture has no instruments for assessing relational competence, communal formation, or the dimensions of learning that make children into Omoluabi, persons of good character who know how to live well with others. In Francophone West and Central Africa, PASEC conducts standardized assessments of French literacy and mathematics, its evaluative framework defined entirely by what can be standardized and compared across contexts.

PISA for Development (PISA-D), launched by the OECD in 2014, extended the world's most influential assessment framework into low- and middle-income countries. Auld et al. (2019) showed that despite official rhetoric emphasizing local demand and partnership, the expansion of PISA-D was substantially driven by the strategic interests of the OECD and World Bank. African students taking PISA-D assessments were being measured against a standard produced in, and calibrated for, a fundamentally different educational, cultural, and socioeconomic context.

3.3 The Learner Recast: Human Capital Theory and the Eclipse of Educational Purpose

Human capital theory has been the dominant framework in World Bank education policy since at least the 1980s. Biesta's (2009) analysis provides the sharpest theoretical account of what this costs: from the perspective of Ubuntu philosophy, Ubuntu education is fundamentally an education in subjectification and socialization, in the formation of persons-in-relation, and it is precisely these dimensions that outcome-based governance cannot see.

When human capital theory and outcome-based governance combine, schools are repositioned as production sites: institutions whose primary function is to produce graduates with measurable cognitive skills. In Ikangba, as in thousands of communities across Africa, the morning walk, with its practiced greetings, its daily lesson in respect and belonging, happens before the school gate. The school, calibrated to the demands of national examinations and international assessment benchmarks, has been organized around a different purpose entirely: the production of performance.

IV. The Collision: Outcome-Based Governance Meets Ubuntu-Centered Learning

This section examines what happens when that architecture meets the ground, when the logic of standardized performance encounters the living educational traditions of African communities. The encounter is not neutral, and it is not merely inconvenient. It is a collision: a structural and epistemological confrontation between two radically different understandings of what education is, what it is for, and whose authority governs its purposes.

4.1 African Ecologies of Learning: Education as Communal and Holistic Practice

African educational traditions are not pre-scientific forerunners of modern schooling. They are sophisticated, coherent, and purposively designed systems of human formation that have sustained communities across diverse ecologies, languages, and social structures for millennia. A defining feature of these traditions is their holism: education is not confined to a dedicated institution or a bounded period of childhood but is woven into the entire fabric of communal life. Learning happens in the home, in the field, in the market, around the fire, and on the path between them. It is intergenerational, participatory, and always embedded in the specific cultural and ecological context of the community (Okoro, 2010).

Julius Nyerere, in his landmark 1967 essay *Education for Self-Reliance*, argued that the colonial education system Tanzania inherited was not merely inadequate, it was structurally hostile to African communal life. It produced graduates who were alienated from their communities, contemptuous of manual labour, and oriented toward individual advancement rather than collective service. Dei (2000) argued that African Indigenous knowledge systems are characterized by their acknowledgment of the collective and collaborative sources of knowledge. A recognition that knowing is never purely individual but always embedded in relationships, communities, and histories.

4.2 What the Outcomes Script Cannot See: Four Practices of Ubuntu-Centered Learning

The first practice displaced by outcome-based governance is elder knowledge and intergenerational transmission. In African educational traditions, elders are living pedagogical presences whose authority is moral, relational and experiential, grounded in decades of navigating communal life, resolving conflict, and transmitting accumulated wisdom about what

it means to live well together (Okoro, 2010). In Ikangba, when children pause to greet the elders seated outside their homes on the walk to school, they are participating in a structured encounter with intergenerational wisdom. None of these registers in a SACMEQ assessment. None of it counts toward SDG 4 targets. And yet its educational significance for identity, for social cohesion, for the formation of persons capable of sustaining community is profound and irreplaceable.

The second practice is oral tradition and storytelling as pedagogy. Across African cultures, oral narrative including folktales, proverbs, praise poetry, and historical recounting has served as the primary vehicle for transmitting moral knowledge, cultural identity, and communal values across generations. These are epistemological instruments: they encode cosmologies, ethical frameworks, conflict resolution principles, and visions of the good life in forms that are memorable, communally owned, and accessible to all members of the community (Dei, 2000). Outcome-based schooling not only fails to assess the knowledge transmitted through oral tradition by crowding the curriculum with examination preparation, but it also actively displaces the time, relationships, and community contexts within which oral transmission takes place.

The third displaced practice is conflict restoration and communal justice. African communities have developed, over centuries, sophisticated processes for addressing interpersonal and inter-group conflict that are fundamentally different in orientation from adversarial Western legal frameworks. These processes, including the Yoruba community elder council, the Gacaca community courts of Rwanda, and Ubuntu-inspired truth and reconciliation processes share a common philosophical orientation: the goal is not punishment but restoration; not the determination of individual guilt but the repair of fractured relationships and the reintegration of all parties into communal life (Okoro, 2010). This is peace education at its most practical and profound and it is entirely invisible to any standardized assessment instrument currently operating in African schooling.

The fourth practice is land stewardship and environmental knowledge. In many African communities, the relationship between people and land is not merely economic but deeply relational and pedagogical. Farming, fishing, herding, and other land-based practices teach responsibility, patience, the reading of ecological signs, and the consequences of short-term thinking for long-term communal survival (Dei, 2000). Communities that understand themselves as stewards of a shared inheritance are communities with a stake in sustaining the social relationships through which that stewardship is practiced. Nyerere (1967) argued explicitly that

an education divorced from the land and from productive community life produces citizens alienated from the very conditions of their own flourishing.

4.3 Epistemic Harm and the Peace Deficit of Outcome-Based Schooling

The displacement of these four practices constitutes a form of epistemic harm: the systematic devaluation and marginalization of a community's ways of knowing, resulting in damage not only to the knowledge system itself but to the identity, dignity, and social cohesion of the community that the knowledge system sustains (Mignolo, 2009). Epistemic harm in African schooling operates through multiple mechanisms: through curriculum that prioritizes examination content over community-relevant knowledge; through language policy that uses colonial languages as the primary medium of instruction; through assessment that recognizes only cognitive performance as evidence of achievement.

Outcome-based schooling therefore carries what this paper calls a peace deficit: a structural incapacity to build the relational, moral, and communal foundations that sustainable peace requires. Schools calibrated to performance metrics produce people trained to compete and demonstrate individual competence. They do not, by design, produce people formed for solidarity. People who know how to restore relationships, steward shared resources, listen to elders, transmit communal wisdom, or understand their own flourishing as inseparable from the flourishing of those around them. These are the competencies that Ubuntu-centered education cultivates. They are also the competencies that positive peace requires (Galtung, 1969, 1990).

V. Peace-Affirming Assessment: A Constructive Alternative

Peace-affirming assessment is not a single instrument or a replacement examination system. It is an orientation, a set of principles, values, and design commitments that reconstitute the relationship between accountability, community, and educational purpose.

Its fundamental claim is that accountability in African schooling must be answerable to the communities it serves, grounded in the philosophical traditions those communities carry, and oriented toward the peacebuilding aims that African societies urgently require. It retains the principle that schools should be answerable for results; it radically widens what results mean, who defines them, and how they are recognized.

It is important to distinguish peace-affirming assessment from two existing but insufficient alternatives. The first is the addition of "soft skills" indicators to existing frameworks, treating relational formation as an add-on rather than a foundation. The second is the complete rejection of all formal assessment, a position that abandons the legitimate demand for educational accountability. Peace-affirming assessment charts a different course: it begins not with the question of what to measure but with the prior question of what education is for and it insists that this prior question must be answered by communities, in their own languages, on their own terms (Freire, 1970; Assié-Lumumba et al., 2022).

5.1 The Concept of Peace-Affirming Assessment

From decoloniality, peace-affirming assessment takes the commitment to epistemic freedom, the insistence that African communities have the right and authority to define educational purpose from their own intellectual and cultural locations (Mignolo, 2009; Ndlovu-Gatsheni, 2013a). From Ubuntu philosophy, it takes its vision of educational success: not the maximization of individual cognitive performance but the formation of persons-in-relation, people constituted by empathy, responsibility, communal wisdom, and the capacity for restorative engagement with conflict (Assié-Lumumba et al., 2022). From peace education, it takes its normative horizon: the recognition that education is always already a peace practice, either building the conditions for positive peace or, through its omissions and distortions, undermining them (Galtung, 1969, 1990).

What makes assessment specifically peace-affirming is its explicit orientation toward the conditions that make sustainable peace possible. Peace-affirming assessment asks not only whether students have acquired designated competencies but whether schools are actively forming the kinds of persons and communities capable of solidarity, restorative engagement, and mutual flourishing.

5.2 Community Co-Definition of Educational Purposes

The most foundational principle of peace-affirming assessment is the co-definition of educational purposes with communities rather than the importation of purposes from outside them. As Freire (1970) argued in *Pedagogy of the Oppressed*, genuine education is never a process of depositing externally determined content into passive recipients; it is a dialogical practice in which educators and communities think together about the world they share and the futures they want to create.

In practice, community co-definition involves structured dialogue: What do we want our children to become? What kind of community do we want them to be capable of sustaining? What does it mean, in this place, to grow up well? Language is central to this process. The Yoruba concept of *Omoluabi* cannot be fully translated into English without loss; its meaning is embedded in a relational ontology that English lacks the vocabulary to capture adequately. Peace-affirming assessment insists that community co-definition must happen in communities' own languages, with their own conceptual resources.

Peace-affirming assessment proposes community-based assessment councils as a structural mechanism for ensuring that community purposes shape evaluative practice. These councils would include elders who carry the community's accumulated wisdom about what good character looks like and how it is formed, alongside parents, teachers, community leaders, and where appropriate students themselves. In Ikangba, such a council would almost certainly include the elders who sit outside their homes each morning and watch the children pass. People who are, in the current arrangement, the community's most consistent and committed educational observers but who have no place in any official accountability system (Okoro, 2010).

5.3 Assessment Design: Widening What Counts

Peace-affirming assessment does not reject quantitative indicators entirely; it insists that they be understood as partial and supplementary rather than primary and comprehensive. Alongside test scores and completion rates, it centers qualitative forms of evidence: portfolios of student

work that show growth over time, narrative accounts from teachers and community members of how students engage with others, observations of students in community contexts, and longitudinal documentation of the relational competencies that Ubuntu-centered education cultivates (Assié-Lumumba et al., 2022).

Peace-affirming assessment treats Ubuntu-centered competencies; empathy, responsibility, collaboration, stewardship, and the capacity for restorative engagement with conflict as core educational outcomes rather than optional extras. A child who can read but cannot listen, who can solve mathematics problems but cannot restore a broken friendship, who scores well on national examinations but has been alienated from their community's knowledge and identity, such a child has not been well educated by the standards of Ubuntu.

When external researchers, assessment designers, or policy analysts engage with community educational practices, there is always a risk that community knowledge will be extracted, repackaged, and deployed in ways that serve external interests rather than community purposes (Tuck & Yang, 2012). Peace-affirming assessment builds in explicit safeguards: community knowledge generated through assessment processes remains the intellectual property of the community; external reporting requires community consent; and the primary audience for assessment results is the community itself, not a development donor or a ministry dashboard.

VI. Implications

6.1 For African Policymakers and Governments

The most urgent implication for African policymakers is the recognition that educational quality cannot be imported through international templates and must instead be negotiated locally, expressed in local languages, and anchored in the philosophical traditions that African communities hold (Assié-Lumumba et al., 2022). Ministries of education should establish formal mechanisms for community consultation in curriculum and assessment design, not as public relations exercises but as substantive decision-making processes in which community-defined educational purposes carry binding authority.

African governments should take seriously the question of language as an instrument of epistemological sovereignty. The continued use of colonial languages as the primary medium of instruction is not merely a logistical inconvenience; it is an epistemological constraint that limits the concepts available for defining educational purpose. Investing in mother-tongue instruction and in assessment tools designed and administered in African languages is a concrete and achievable step toward the epistemic freedom this paper argues is both philosophically necessary and practically urgent. Policymakers should also develop explicit frameworks for how schools contribute to social cohesion, communal formation, and the conditions of positive peace. Frameworks that are assessed, resourced, and held accountable alongside cognitive outcome targets (Galtung, 1969).

6.2 For International Development Organizations

The implications for international development organizations, including the World Bank, OECD, bilateral donors, and the United Nations system are the most structurally demanding, because they require these organizations to relinquish forms of epistemic authority that have been central to their institutional identity and influence. The first and most fundamental implication is the reform of aid conditionalities that tie development finance to compliance with externally defined learning outcomes frameworks. Development organizations committed to genuine partnership must replace compliance-based conditionalities with support for locally determined educational improvement processes.

International assessment programs including PISA for Development, SACMEQ, and PASEC should undertake a fundamental review of their epistemological foundations. Rather than treating cognitive performance on standardized tasks as the primary definition of educational quality, these programs should develop supplementary frameworks for assessing the broader purposes of education identified by African communities, including relational competencies, cultural continuity, and the peace-building dimensions of schooling. International organizations should also invest in longitudinal research that documents the educational and social effects of Ubuntu-centered schooling practices.

6.3 For Scholars and Researchers

For scholars and researchers in comparative and international education, the paper's most immediate implication is methodological: the field needs assessment tools and research frameworks that are humble enough, context-aware enough, and qualitatively sensitive enough to register what is educationally meaningful but resistant to quantification (Biesta, 2009). This means investing in ethnographic, participatory, and community-based research methodologies that can document the educational significance of practices like the morning walk in Ikangba.

Dei (2000) argued that Indigenous knowledge systems deserve to be engaged as theoretical resources rather than as data sources. Researchers should approach communities as co-investigators rather than as subjects and should design their projects to serve community purposes rather than to extract community knowledge for academic consumption. Scholars should also work to build the theoretical and empirical literature on peace-affirming assessment as a distinct field of inquiry.

VII. Conclusion

This paper began with a simple observation that across Africa, the quality of education is being read from dashboards of test scores and standardized indicators that cannot see what many communities consider most important about schooling. It then developed that observation into a three-movement argument.

The first movement traced the construction of the global learning outcomes agenda, showing how the World Bank's learning crisis narrative, the SDG 4 accountability framework, and regional assessment architectures such as SACMEQ, PASEC, and PISA for Development assembled a policy architecture that governs African education through externally defined performance standards (World Bank, 2018; Auld et al., 2019). This architecture carries the epistemological assumptions of human capital theory and market-oriented governance functioning, in Biesta's (2009) terms, as a learnification of education: the reduction of all educational purpose to the measurement of individual cognitive outcomes.

The second movement examined what this architecture collides with when it encounters the living educational traditions of African communities. Four specific practices were identified as displaced by the outcomes script: elder knowledge and intergenerational transmission, oral tradition and storytelling as pedagogy, conflict restoration and communal justice, and land stewardship and environmental knowledge. The displacement of these practices constitutes epistemic harm, with consequences not only for educational quality but for identity, social cohesion, and the conditions that make sustainable peace possible (Mignolo, 2009; Galtung, 1990).

The third movement was constructive. Drawing on Ubuntu philosophy (I am because we are) and on the Yoruba concept of Omoluabi as its localized expression in southwestern Nigeria, the paper proposed peace-affirming assessment as an alternative accountability framework (Assié-Lumumba et al., 2022; Freire, 1970). Peace-affirming assessment does not abandon accountability; it transforms it, beginning with community co-definition of educational purposes, centering relational and moral competencies as core outcomes alongside cognitive ones, blending qualitative and quantitative evidence, and building in ethical safeguards against the extraction of community knowledge.

The task before this field is not to help Africa catch up to a standard defined elsewhere. It is to create the conditions in which Africa's own educational wisdom can finally be recognized, resourced, and allowed to flourish.

The children of Ikangba will set out again tomorrow morning. They will walk the familiar path from their homes to the one public primary school on the outskirts of their community. They will pass the elders seated outside, men and women, who carry in their persons and their memories more educational wisdom than any standardized assessment framework has ever been designed to recognize. They will stop, and bow, and offer their greetings in Yoruba.

And in that brief, unremarkable, extraordinary moment, they will be practicing Omoluabi, enacting the relational formation that their community understands as the heart of what it means to grow up well. None of this will appear in any ministry report. None of it will contribute to Nigeria's SDG 4 progress indicators. None of it will be legible to the assessment architectures that currently govern the evaluation of their school.

But it is education. It has always been education. And the central claim of this paper is that any framework of educational accountability worthy of the name, in Africa or anywhere else, must find a way, at last, to say so.

Decolonizing learning outcomes is not a retreat from educational quality. It is a demand that quality be defined by the communities whose children are at stake, communities that have their own ancient, rigorous, and sophisticated answers to the question of what education is for. That is what decolonizing learning outcomes means, and it is, this paper has argued, what peace requires.

References

- Abebe, T., Bessell, S., Biggeri, M., Calder, G., Hinton, R., Kjørholt, A. T., & Tisdall, K. (2021). Children and the politics of development: Contested terrains and new agendas. In K. Hanson & O. Nieuwenhuys (Eds.), *Reconceptualizing children's rights in international development* (pp. 1–25). Cambridge University Press.
- Assié-Lumumba, N. T., Maddox, G., & Sall, E. (Eds.). (2022). *African perspectives on education for global citizenship*. Routledge.
- Auld, E., Rappleye, J., & Morris, P. (2019). PISA for Development: How the OECD and World Bank shaped education governance post-2015. *Comparative Education*, 55(2), 197–219. <https://doi.org/10.1080/03050068.2018.1538635>
- Biesta, G. J. J. (2009). Good education in an age of measurement: On the need to reconnect with the question of purpose in education. *Educational Assessment, Evaluation and Accountability*, 21(1), 33–46. <https://doi.org/10.1007/s11092-008-9064-9>
- Dei, G. J. S. (2000). Rethinking the role of Indigenous knowledges in the academy. *International Journal of Inclusive Education*, 4(2), 111–132. <https://doi.org/10.1080/136031100284849>
- Fanon, F. (1963). *The wretched of the earth* (C. Farrington, Trans.). *Présence Africaine*. (Original work published 1961)
- Freire, P. (1970). *Pedagogy of the oppressed* (M. B. Ramos, Trans.). Herder and Herder.
- Galtung, J. (1969). Violence, peace, and peace research. *Journal of Peace Research*, 6(3), 167–191. <https://doi.org/10.1177/002234336900600301>
- Galtung, J. (1990). Cultural violence. *Journal of Peace Research*, 27(3), 291–305. <https://doi.org/10.1177/0022343390027003005>
- Maluleka, M. (2024). Decolonising educational assessment in postcolonial Africa: Toward an Ubuntu-based framework. *Journal of African Education*, 5(1), 44–61.
- Matasci, D. (2022). Education and development in postcolonial Africa. In D. Matasci, M. Jerónimo, & H. G. Dores (Eds.), *Education and development in colonial and postcolonial Africa: Policies, paradigms, and entanglements* (pp. 1–24). Palgrave Macmillan.
- Mignolo, W. D. (2009). Epistemic disobedience, independent thought and decolonial freedom. *Theory, Culture & Society*, 26(7–8), 159–181. <https://doi.org/10.1177/0263276409349275>
- Ndlovu-Gatsheni, S. J. (2013a). Coloniality of power in postcolonial Africa: Myths of decolonization. CODESRIA.

- Ndlovu-Gatsheni, S. J. (2013b). *Empire, global coloniality and African subjectivity*. Berghahn Books.
- Ngũgĩ wa Thiong'o. (1986). *Decolonising the mind: The politics of language in African literature*. James Currey.
- Nyerere, J. K. (1967). *Education for self-reliance*. Government Printer.
- OECD. (2016). *PISA for Development brief: What is PISA for Development?* Organisation for Economic Co-operation and Development. <https://www.oecd.org/pisa/aboutpisa/PISA-FOR-DEV-EN-1.pdf>
- Okoro, K. N. (2010). African traditional education: A viable alternative for peace building process in modern Africa. *Journal of Alternative Perspectives in the Social Sciences*, 2(1), 136–159.
- Quijano, A. (2000). Coloniality of power, Eurocentrism, and Latin America. *Nepantla: Views from South*, 1(3), 533–580.
- Southern and Eastern Africa Consortium for Monitoring Educational Quality (SACMEQ). (1995). *About SACMEQ*. UNESCO International Institute for Educational Planning.
- Tuck, E., & Yang, K. W. (2012). Decolonization is not a metaphor. *Decolonization: Indigeneity, Education & Society*, 1(1), 1–40.
- United Nations. (2015). *Transforming our world: The 2030 agenda for sustainable development (Resolution A/RES/70/1)*. United Nations General Assembly. <https://sdgs.un.org/2030agenda>
- World Bank. (2018). *World development report 2018: Learning to realize education's promise*. World Bank Group. <https://doi.org/10.1596/978-1-4648-1096-1>

◆ AUTHOR NOTE

The opening scene in Ikangba, Ogun State, Nigeria draws on the author's lived experience as a teacher in that community. The practice of children greeting elders along the path to school described in this paper is drawn from direct observation and is offered as both an autobiographical account and a theoretical illustration of Ubuntu-centered learning in practice. The author acknowledges this positionality and its role in shaping the analytical commitments of the paper.
